

# The Usurper's Gambit

## An Adventure for Fate's Edge - Ecktoria

### Adventure Overview

**Title:** The Usurper's Gambit  
**Region:** Ecktoria – Marble, Brass, & Fire  
**Theme:** Legitimacy, bureaucracy, ritual power, imperial decline  
**Level:** Veteran (Tier III)  
**Length:** 4–5 Sessions

### 1 Premise

Ecktoria, heir to the shattered Utaran Empire, stands on the knife-edge of civil conflict. A charismatic pretender has seized the loyalty of the capital militia, silenced dissenting censors, and begun invoking ancient rites to claim the Mandate of Everflame. Meanwhile, the recognized heir — King Aldric the Lamé — clings to legitimacy through law, tradition, and the blessing of the High Temple.

The players navigate a city where every marble colonnade hides a conspiracy, every mosaic conveys a political message, and every oath is engraved in red-lacquered tablets guarded by the Censors. They must decide: bolster one claimant, forge a third path, or engineer a peaceful transfer of power in a system designed to resist change violently.

### 2 Hook

Choose or roll (DV 3 Investigation to determine truth):

- **The Envoy's Humiliation:** Before the Great Baths of Aurix, the Lamé King's Envoy is publicly mocked, their ceremonial staff struck from their hand — a grave insult in Ecktoria. The crowd cheers the Pretender's heralds. (Social/Skill challenge, Presence + Command vs DV 4)
- **A Dead Man's Seal:** A courier collapses into the players' arms with a sealed tablet bearing the mark of a supposedly-dead claimant. If true, a surviving cousin could upend every faction's plans. (Investigation + Lore vs DV 5)
- **A Contract Invalidated:** A lucrative patronage contract is voided by a Senate Decree — half the Senate claims the decree is legal, the other half claims the seals were forged. (Legal investigation, Sway + Lore vs DV 4)

### 3 Key Factions

#### 3.1 The Lame King's Line

##### The Lame King's Line

**Description:** Imperial-bureaucratic loyalists adhering to law and tradition

**Key Members:** High Priest of Everflame, Coin-House Factors, Veteran Standard-Bearers

**Strengths:** Ritualistic power, institutional authority, legal legitimacy

**Weaknesses:** Slow, cautious, inflexible

**Methods:** Ceremonial rites, legal procedures, traditional military

**Position:** Controlled (established authority), Desperate (losing popular support)

**DV for Alliance:** 4 (mutual benefit), 5 (neutral), 6+ (opposed)

#### 3.2 The Pretender's Cause

##### The Pretender's Cause

**Description:** Reformist movement promising "New Augustan Revival"

**Key Members:** Reformist Senators, Condotta Captains, New Merchants

**Strengths:** Popular support, military flexibility, economic influence

**Weaknesses:** Shallow legal standing, reliance on charisma

**Methods:** Public demonstrations, military action, economic pressure

**Position:** Dominant (popular momentum), may shift to Controlled under pressure

**DV for Alliance:** 3 (shared goals), 4 (neutral), 5+ (opposed)

#### 3.3 The Silent Opposition

##### The Silent Opposition

**Description:** Reject both claimants, seek provincial autonomy

**Key Members:** Guild Conspiracies, Shadow Council, Regional Governors

**Strengths:** Economic sabotage, decentralized structure, patience

**Weaknesses:** Disunity, lack of public support

**Methods:** Economic pressure, covert operations, political manipulation

**Position:** Controlled (hidden influence), may shift based on player actions

**DV for Alliance:** 4 (shared opposition), 5 (neutral), 6+ (competing interests)

## 4 Key NPCs

### 4.1 King Aldric the Lane

#### King Aldric the Lane

**Role:** Recognized heir to Ecktoria

**Age:** 45

**Skills:** Command 4, Lore 3, Presence 3

**Knowledge:** Imperial law, ceremonial rites, political tradition

**Motivation:** Preserve legitimate succession and imperial stability

**Complication:** Physical disability affects public perception

**Position:** Controlled (legitimate authority), Desperate (losing ground)

**DV for Persuasion:** 4 (appeal to duty), 5 (neutral), 6 (opposed)

### 4.2 Duke Logan the Bold

#### Duke Logan the Bold

**Role:** Charismatic pretender to the throne

**Age:** 38

**Skills:** Presence 5, Sway 4, Command 3

**Knowledge:** Public relations, military rites, popular sentiment

**Motivation:** Seize power through popular support and reform

**Complication:** Limited understanding of true imperial traditions

**Position:** Dominant (popular support), Controlled under legal pressure

**DV for Manipulation:** 3 (flattery), 4 (neutral), 5+ (opposition)

### 4.3 Grand Magistrate Valeria Thorne

#### Grand Magistrate Valeria Thorne

**Role:** Keeper of imperial law and succession precedents

**Age:** 52

**Skills:** Lore 5, Insight 4, Sway 2

**Knowledge:** Every precedent for imperial succession, Pact of Three Flames

**Motivation:** Preserve legal integrity of imperial system

**Complication:** Torn between legal duty and political reality

**Position:** Controlled (institutional power), Desperate (personal safety)

**DV for Legal Consultation:** 4 (proper approach), 5 (neutral), 6+ (hostile)

## 4.4 High Priest Dominicus

### High Priest Dominicus

**Role:** Keeper of the Sacred Brazier and Everflame

**Age:** 67

**Skills:** Arcana 4, Presence 3, Lore 3

**Knowledge:** Coronation rites, divine signs, spiritual legitimacy

**Motivation:** Ensure rightful claimant receives divine blessing

**Complication:** Torn between stability and renewal

**Position:** Dominant (religious authority), Controlled under political pressure

**DV for Spiritual Guidance:** 3 (genuine seeking), 4 (neutral), 5+ (manipulation)

## 4.5 The Lamé King's Envoy

### The Lamé King's Envoy

**Role:** Mysterious representative of King Aldric

**Skills:** Subterfuge 4, Insight 3, Command 2

**Knowledge:** Secret negotiations, hidden political moves

**Motivation:** Advance Aldric's cause through covert means

**Complication:** Unknown true identity and loyalties

**Position:** Controlled (operating in shadows), Desperate if exposed

**DV for Information:** 5 (secrecy), 4 (proper approach), 3 (trusted ally)

## 5 Key Locations

### 5.1 The Grand Forum

#### The Grand Forum

**Description:** Marble theater of politics with multi-level balconies

**Features:** Statues of emperors, mosaic floors, colored awnings

**Political Significance:** Center of public opinion and political theater

**Challenges:**

- Navigating public sentiment (Presence + Sway vs DV 4)
- Interpreting political symbols (Lore + Notice vs DV 3)
- Avoiding public humiliation (Social challenge, DV 5)

**Position:** Controlled (normal), may shift based on current political climate

## 5.2 Imperial Arena

### Imperial Arena

**Description:** Site of trials by ordeal and ceremonial oaths

**Features:** Underground tunnels, ceremonial spaces, public viewing areas

**Uses:** Military demonstrations, legal trials, political statements

**Challenges:**

- Participating in trials by ordeal (Varies by trial type)
- Navigating underground tunnels (Stealth + Athletics vs DV 4)
- Public performance under pressure (Presence + Command vs DV 5)

**Security:** Heavily guarded during public events

## 5.3 Coin-House Floor

### Coin-House Floor

**Description:** Byzantine-style financial temple with gold seals and clerks

**Features:** Abacus-boards, wax tablets, chanting clerks

**Power:** Financial control can bankrupt provinces or fund armies

**Challenges:**

- Understanding financial records (Lore + Wits vs DV 5)
- Bribing or influencing clerks (Sway vs DV 4)
- Sabotaging ledgers (Tinker + Subterfuge vs DV 6)

**Position:** Controlled (legitimate business), Desperate (illegal activity)

## 5.4 Censor's Hall

### Censor's Hall

**Description:** Labyrinth of documents, shame-tablets, and censored histories

**Features:** Red lacquer tablets, genealogical records, censored archives

**Significance:** Maintains The Line of Fire - genealogical record of claimants

**Challenges:**

- Finding specific documents (Investigation vs DV 5)
- Deciphering censored texts (Lore vs DV 4)
- Avoiding detection (Stealth + Subterfuge vs DV 5)

**Security:** Extremely tight - access requires high-level authorization

## 5.5 The Fire-Blessed Basilica

### The Fire-Blessed Basilica

**Description:** Spiritual heart with gold and lapis dome depicting Everflame

**Features:** Sacred Brazier, ceremonial spaces, religious artifacts

**Importance:** Final coronation ritual must occur here

**Challenges:**

- Gaining access during blockade (Combat/Skill challenge, DV 5)
- Participating in coronation rites (Varies by role)
- Convincing High Priest (Presence + Sway vs DV 5)

**Current Status:** Blockaded by Pretender's forces

## 6 Adventure Structure

### 6.1 Act I — Cracks in Marble

**Opening Scene:** Players witness public demonstration of shifting power through one of the hook scenarios.

**Key Objectives:**

- Investigate signs of Pretender's growing influence
- Determine if Duke Logan's claim has substance
- Identify key supporters and opponents of each faction
- Begin building relationships with influential NPCs

**Sample Encounters:**

- **Statue Alteration Investigation:** Notice and investigate changes to imperial statues. (Investigation + Notice vs DV 4, Controlled/Limited)
- **Militia Patrol Encounter:** Deal with new militia wearing unfamiliar colors. (Social/Combat encounter, DV 4)
- **Political Rumor Gathering:** Collect information from Forum conversations. (Sway + Insight vs DV 3, Dominant/Limited)

**Act End:** Players discover evidence of systematic effort to legitimize Pretender's claim. Advance Legitimacy Timer +2.

### 6.2 Act II — Shadows in the Censorium

**Opening Scene:** Grand Magistrate Valeria Thorne is attacked; players must respond.

**Key Objectives:**

- Protect or avenge Grand Magistrate Thorne
- Navigate Censor's Hall to uncover truth about succession

- Find or protect the Pact of Three Flames
- Expose forged genealogies or hidden legitimate claimants

**Sample Encounters:**

- **Censor's Hall Infiltration:** Sneak through document labyrinth. (Stealth + Investigation vs DV 5, Desperate/Standard)
- **Genealogical Puzzle:** Verify authenticity of claimant lineages. (Lore + Insight vs DV 6, Controlled/Great)
- **Archivist Interrogation:** Extract information from knowledgeable but secretive clerks. (Sway + Insight vs DV 4, Controlled/Standard)

**Act End:** Players gain crucial legal knowledge about succession. Advance either Lame King's or Pretender's Legal Standing Timer +2.

### 6.3 Act III — Coin, Steel, and Fire

**Opening Scene:** Pretender's forces blockade the Basilica; crisis point reached.

**Key Objectives:**

- Mediate between factions or choose sides
- Sabotage opposing faction's efforts
- Escalate conflict through strategic actions
- Prepare for final confrontation at coronation

**Sample Encounters:**

- **Coin-House Sabotage:** Disrupt financial support for one faction. (Tinker + Subterfuge vs DV 5, Desperate/Standard)
- **Mercantile Leverage:** Negotiate with New Merchants for support. (Sway + Command vs DV 4, Controlled/Great)
- **Basilica Siege:** Break through Pretender's blockade. (Combat/Strategy challenge, DV 6)

**Act End:** Players position themselves for final act. Advance Coronation Readiness Timer +2.

### 6.4 Act IV — The Coronation of Ash or Glory

**Opening Scene:** Dawn at the Basilica; final confrontation begins.

**Key Objectives:**

- Decide which claimant to support or oppose
- Participate in coronation ritual and Trial of the Everflame
- Deal with consequences of previous choices
- Determine Ecktoria's future political structure

**Sample Encounters:**

- **Rhetorical Duel:** Participate in public debate before the people. (Presence + Sway vs DV 5, Desperate/Great)
- **Ritual Combat:** Engage in ceremonial combat under priestly supervision. (Melee + Spirit vs DV 5, Desperate/Great)
- **Miraculous Display:** Create or expose fake divine signs. (Arcana + Subterfuge vs DV 6, Controlled/Great)

**Act End:** Resolution of succession crisis. All timers culminate in final outcome.

## 7 Key Mechanics

### 7.1 Legitimacy Timer [8]

**Advance +1:** Public demonstrations support Pretender

**Advance +1:** Lame King's supporters lose ground

**Advance +2:** Key legal documents are compromised

**Advance +1:** Religious figures declare for Pretender

**Advance +2:** Military units defect to Pretender

**When Full:** Pretender achieves effective control of capital

### 7.2 Legal Standing Timer [6] (Separate for each claimant)

**Advance +1:** Genealogical evidence discovered

**Advance +1:** Precedent found supporting claim

**Advance +2:** Key legal figure declares support

**Advance +1:** Ceremonial requirements met

**When Full:** Claimant achieves legal legitimacy

### 7.3 Coronation Readiness Timer [6]

**Advance +1:** Religious preparations completed

**Advance +1:** Military support secured

**Advance +2:** Public opinion shifts decisively

**Advance +1:** Ceremonial artifacts gathered

**Advance +1:** Opposing faction neutralized

**When Full:** Coronation can proceed

## 7.4 Imperial Favor Track

**Exalted:** +2 die to all imperial interactions, access to highest circles

**Respected:** +1 die to imperial interactions, normal access

**Neutral:** Standard imperial interactions

**Suspect:** -1 die to imperial interactions, limited access

**Enemy:** Hostile reactions, wanted by authorities

## 8 Endings

### 8.1 Aldric Crowned Lawfully

Aldric Crowned Lawfully

Lame King's Legal Standing Timer fills first

Stable but static Ecktoria that prizes tradition

- Official positions in imperial bureaucracy
- Access to traditional imperial resources
- Honor and respect among conservative factions
- May become tools of rigid bureaucracy
- Ongoing tension with reformist elements
- Limited ability to drive significant change

### 8.2 Logan Claims the Throne

Logan Claims the Throne

Pretender's Legal Standing Timer fills first

Revitalized but turbulent empire driven by reform

- Positions in new imperial administration
- Access to military and mercantile resources
- Opportunity for rapid advancement
- Navigate rapid militarization and upheaval
- Deal with foreign ambitions and internal opposition
- Risk being purged if Logan consolidates power

### 8.3 A Third Path

#### A Third Path

Players engineer alternative solution

- Install hidden legitimate claimant
- Establish Council of Three Flames
- Create regional autonomy under imperial oversight
- Key roles in new political structure
- Unique position bridging factions
- Significant influence over Ecktoria's future
- Ongoing responsibility for maintaining balance
- Enemies from disappointed factions
- Future adventure hooks across Ecktoria

### 8.4 Ecktoria Falls

#### Ecktoria Falls

All timers fill without decisive resolution

City collapses into street warfare

- Unchallenged power in local territory
- Freedom to pursue personal agenda
- Reputation as survivor and leader
- Destruction of imperial institutions
- Ongoing chaos and instability
- Need to rebuild order from ashes

## 9 Rewards and Consequences

### 9.1 Immediate Rewards

- Imperial Signet Ring: +1 die to bureaucratic interactions
- Ceremonial Blade: Elegant weapon with historical significance
- Red Lacquer Tablet: Document granting special legal privileges
- Merchant's Charter: License for tax-free trade in Ecktoria
- Priest's Blessing: +1 die to religious interactions
- Military Commission: Temporary authority over small unit

## 9.2 Long-term Consequences

- **Aldric Victory:** Permanent positions in traditional bureaucracy, conservative allies, reformist enemies
- **Logan Victory:** Roles in new administration, military/mercantile connections, traditionalist opposition
- **Third Path:** Unique political influence, cross-faction relationships, ongoing responsibility for stability
- **Ecktor's Fall:** Survival skills and local power base, but destroyed traditional institutions and ongoing chaos

## 10 GM Notes

### 10.1 Political Complexity

Emphasize the Byzantine nature of Ecktorian politics:

- Every action has multiple interpretations and consequences
- Legal precedents can be interpreted in conflicting ways
- Public opinion shifts based on ceremonial displays and rhetoric
- Economic power is as important as military force

### 10.2 Ceremonial Importance

Make ritual and ceremony central to the adventure:

- Proper titles and protocols matter for social interactions
- Ceremonial objects and locations have real power
- Public performances can shift political momentum
- Religious rites determine ultimate legitimacy

### 10.3 Bureaucratic Atmosphere

Create a sense of the weight of imperial tradition:

- Describe marble halls, gold decorations, and ceremonial regalia
- Emphasize the importance of proper documentation and seals
- Show the slow but powerful movement of imperial institutions
- Illustrate the contrast between public grandeur and hidden manipulation

## 10.4 Player Agency

Provide multiple paths to influence the outcome:

- Legal approach: Master imperial law and precedent
- Social approach: Manipulate public opinion and personal relationships
- Military approach: Use force to support chosen faction
- Economic approach: Control financial resources and trade
- Religious approach: Influence spiritual legitimacy

## 10.5 Story Beats

Use the political environment for complications:

- 1 SB: Minor bureaucratic delay, small legal complication
- 2 SB: Important document goes missing, key NPC becomes suspicious
- 3 SB: Public scandal damages faction, military unit defects
- 4+ SB: Major political upheaval, assassination attempt, ceremonial disaster

## 10.6 Session-Specific Guidance

**Session 1 Focus:** Establish political landscape and hook players into the conflict. Players should understand both claimants have strengths and weaknesses.

**Session 2 Focus:** Deep dive into legal and archival aspects. Players learn that legitimacy is complex and can be influenced.

**Session 3 Focus:** Crisis point with Basilica blockade. Players must make strategic choices that affect final outcome.

**Session 4 Focus:** Climactic resolution and consequences. All previous elements converge in final choices about Ecktoria's future.

## 10.7 Alternative Endings

If players attempt unconventional solutions:

- **Popular Uprising:** Players incite general revolt against both claimants
- **Foreign Intervention:** Players invite external power to resolve succession
- **Religious Solution:** Players convince High Priest to reject both claimants
- **Economic Coup:** Players use financial power to force political resolution

## 10.8 Scaling for Different Tiers

**Tier III (Veteran):** Standard complexity with significant political and military resources.

**Tier IV (Paragon):** Add foreign power complications, multiple simultaneous succession crises, and empire-wide implications.

**Tier V (Mythic):** Introduce divine intervention, reality-altering political magic, and consequences that reshape the entire region.